

MANEESH AGNIHOTRI

ULEMA COUNCIL PARTICIPANTS
AT THEIR MEETING; (BELOW) THE
LAUNCH OF ANOTHER FRONT



Feb 23, 2009: UP MILLI MAHAZ
Formed by three existing parties—PPI, AIMM and NLP, all of which have fought elections. Wants to create a secular-democratic outfit and a third front of Muslim-led parties. The AIMM is a known party since 1968 and the other two have their own areas of influence.

Feb 19: ULEMA COUNCIL
Held rallies in Delhi and Lucknow and plans to contest 8 seats in Uttar Pradesh. May help polarise votes in favour of the BJP.

Feb 16: SECULAR EKTA PARTY
Formed by Haji Shahid Akhlaque, after denial of ticket by SP. He was BSP's

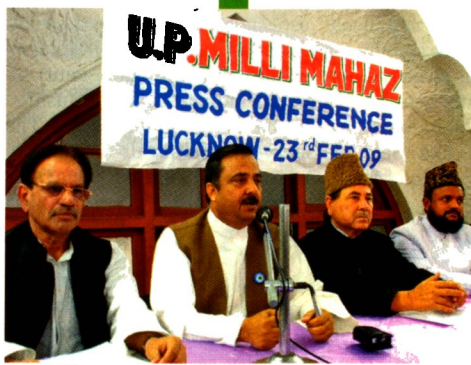
Lok Sabha MP in 2004 and later joined the SP. May create an impact in Meerut with former minister Haji Yaqoob.

Feb 8: MMK
Launched in Chennai to strive for the development of the nation, welfare of minorities and the underprivileged sections. MMK coordinator M.H. Jawahirullah says the party was launched with a view to establish "a strong India through service to the society." New in the political arena and just a beginner.

Feb 2, 2009: UNITED DEMOCRATIC FRONT
Launched by Maulana Badruddin Ajmal of AUDF which won 13 seats in the 2005 Assam polls. Called the MUDF in Maharashtra, the

party, along with other outfits, can affect the BSP and SP in western Uttar Pradesh.

Feb 10, 2008: PEACE PARTY OF INDIA
Launched by surgeon Dr Mohammad Ayub to unite Dalits, Muslims and the backward classes. May have an impact in pockets of eastern Uttar Pradesh.



SANJAY SONKAR

stance, has seen a new Muslim-based political party Manidaneya Makkal Katchi (MMK). According to M.H. Jawahirullah, coordinator, MMK, the party will establish "a strong India... As a Muslim, it is our fundamental duty to strive for the development of our nation."

While much of the political churning has to do with Uttar Pradesh, the parties are of significance considering the importance of the Muslim vote. Muslims form more than 30 per cent of the electorate in 42 of the 543 Lok Sabha constituencies in the country. West Bengal accounts for 10 of them; Uttar Pradesh and Kerala come next with eight each while Assam and J&K account for five each. However, in constituencies where their percentage is between 20 and 30 per cent, the number of seats rises to a staggering 140, including 20 in Uttar Pradesh. The highest concentration of Muslims (between 10 and 20 per cent) is in Uttar Pradesh (42 constituencies), West Bengal (20), Bihar (17), Assam, Karnataka and Kerala (8 each), Maharashtra (7), J&K, Rajasthan and Andhra Pradesh (6 each). In any Lok Sabha poll calculus, Uttar Pradesh—and consequently the Muslim vote—is the key. In the 1998 Lok Sabha polls only 7 per cent of Muslims voted for the BSP and 61 per cent voted for the SP, and in the 2007 Assembly polls, 32 per cent voted for the BSP and 40 per cent for the SP. Mayawati's plan to turn the division in her favour could well upset Mulayam's calculations. The Mulayam camp believes their leader would regain the confidence of Muslims once candidates and alliances are in place.

So what impact would the new Muslim-oriented groupings have on traditional poll arithmetic? Analysts believe new parties like the UC might end up helping the BJP. "Its provocative slogans and posturing would polarise voters in favour of the BJP," said Muslim Majlis vice-president Bader Kazmi. Others think that Uttar

Pradesh already has seen a number of Muslim outfits that fell by the wayside. Existing Muslim parties include Salauddin Khan's People's Democratic Front (PDF), the Peace Party of India led by surgeon Mohammad Ayub, the Majlis-e-Mashawart and the National Loktantrik Party. There is also the Insaan Dosti Party, led by former director-general of police S.M. Naseem. But